

Am I burned out or just having a hard stretch

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 5 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

Tiredness and burnout feel different from the inside. Going flat and cold toward work and people you used to care about **isn't the same as being tired**, and a weekend or two doesn't shift it.

THE GOAL

You're working out, honestly, which one this stretch has been. Write down how many weeks it has run without a proper break, and name one thing that's changed besides your energy.

CHECKLIST

Sunday evening, dreading the week ahead again, trying to work out whether this is ordinary or something you need to act on.

- ☐ Open a note or grab paper, and write **today's date** at the top.
- ☐ Under it, write one sentence naming what's actually different about this stretch, not just that you're tired.
- ☐ Write down how many weeks this has run without a real break in it.
- ☐ Check whether feeling flat and checked-out toward your work stays there, or follows you into evenings and days off too.
- ☐ Name one person or task at work you've started avoiding or writing off. If nothing comes to mind, write 'nothing yet.'
- ☐ If you wrote 'nothing yet,' pick one evening this week to protect completely: phone in another room, no work chat.
- ☐ If you wrote 'nothing yet,' set a date to reread this note, say two weeks out, and check whether the tired has lifted.
- ☐ If you named someone or something, write next to it exactly what changed: less patience, going through the motions, or avoiding it outright.
- ☐ If you named someone or something, write one line on why: something that changed at work, not just the hours.
- ☐ If you named someone or something, say it once out loud, plainly: **'I think I'm past tired at work.'**
- ☐ If you named someone or something, pick one person to tell who isn't the source of it: a partner, a friend, or your manager.
- ☐ If you named someone or something, set a date, say two weeks out, to check the thing you named, not how tired you feel.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** The flat, don't-care feeling toward people and tasks you once cared about is itself **part of what burnout means**.
- 2** You don't need to feel depressed for this to count; it's defined by exhaustion, cynicism and feeling ineffective at work.
- 3** Don't wait for a test, score or official diagnosis before deciding this is worth taking seriously.

What actually separates the two

WATCH

The flat, don't-care feeling toward people and tasks you once cared about is itself **part of what burnout means**.

Pulling away from people and tasks is a named part of the definition, and it's specifically what separates burnout from ordinary tiredness. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

You don't need to feel depressed for this to count; it's defined by exhaustion, cynicism and feeling ineffective at work.

A definition built on exhaustion, distancing and feeling ineffective can be true of you even on a day your mood reads as completely fine. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Don't wait for a test, score or official diagnosis before deciding this is worth taking seriously.

Clinical research has never settled on a cut-off score for burnout, so a formal diagnosis isn't something that's **ever coming** to confirm it. [Source 2](#)

WATCH

Burnout's definition is limited to work; a flat, checked-out feeling that reaches into every part of life is measuring something else.

The classification explicitly limits the term to the occupational context, so a feeling that reaches into all of life is measuring something wider than this. [Source 3](#)

Where it actually comes from

KNOW

Research traces burnout mainly to conditions at work, not a personal shortfall in stamina, even though most advice you'll hear focuses on how to individually cope better.

The evidence points at the workplace, yet common advice, like better time management, still aims at the individual instead of what's actually driving it. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Burnout research now spans occupations well beyond nursing, teaching and medicine, and reaches into science and engineering too.

The review's own scope, and its focus on science and engineering fields, treats burnout as a hazard reaching well past frontline caregiving work. [Source 4](#)

What waiting on it costs you

DON'T

Don't take feeling rested after a break as proof this is handled.

Burnout is defined as coming from workplace stress that was never actually managed, and a break clears tiredness without touching what went unmanaged. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Push through this long enough unchanged, and the real risk isn't a bad quarter. It's wanting to leave the job.

Across a majority of the studies reviewed, burnout usually leads to wanting to leave the job, not just a rough quarter. [Source 4](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you're struggling this much, it's because you can't handle stress the way other people can.

ACTUALLY

A study of Norwegian engineers found burnout risk rises only once engagement tips past a healthy point, not that any extra effort leaves you more drained. Struggling like this can track pushing past your limit, not an inability to handle things. [Source 5](#)

Sources

1. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4911781/>
2. <https://www.stressmeasurement.org/burnout>
3. <https://www.who.int/standards/classifications/frequently-asked-questions/burn-out-an-occupational-phenomenon>
4. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK614516/>
5. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6603860/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Too much work and burnout at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)